

CASE BRIEF – THE BARBARIAN'S CUP

Region: Macau / Hong Kong / South China Sea

Case Duration: 10 days (columns 10 → 1)

Artifact: Bodhidharma's Teacup (Tier 2 – Threatening)

Sessions: 2–4

MYSTERY STATEMENT

"A Tier 2 artifact – Bodhidharma's teacup, which turns any liquid it touches into lethal poison while preserving all physical properties – is being auctioned on the Macau black market to a terrorist cell and a pharmaceutical company, while the last surviving guardian monk races to recover it before someone poisons a city or releases a 'cure' that is worse than the disease."

THE REAL STORY

What the Cup Is

Bodhidharma's teacup is not a weapon. It was a tool of enlightenment, brewed by the monk who brought Chan Buddhism to China. For a thousand years, Shaolin monks maintained it with a daily ritual: fill with green tea, let it sit, pour onto the roots of the oldest tree. The tea was "poison to delusion" – killing attachment, illusion, the sleep of avoidance. In 1966, the Cultural Revolution reached the monastery. A 14-year-old novice hid the cup in a wall cavity. He spent 8 years in a labor camp. The cup spent 20 years alone. Without the daily ritual, its nature drifted. "Poison to delusion" became simply poison. The cup does not know it changed. It still hums when near liquid. It still thinks it's brewing wakefulness.

What Happened

Six weeks ago, a looter found the cup in the abandoned monastery and sold it to a Hong Kong antiques dealer for \$200. The dealer tested it on a plant – the plant died in 30 seconds. He contacted João Rosário in Macau, who recognized the cup from a Covenant watch-list he was shown years ago (Rosário has a complicated history with the Covenant – he's been an informant, a target, and a broker, sometimes simultaneously). Rosário organized a blind auction. Three bidders emerged: the Al-Quds Liberation Front (fictional extremist group, \$4.2M bid), Daewon Pharmaceutical (Seoul-based, \$7M bid, they believe the poison mechanism can be isolated to kill viruses and cancer), and – quietly, through an intermediary – Shi Yánxìn, the now-74-year-old monk who hid the cup in 1966 and has been searching for it since his release from the labor camp.

RESOLUTION PATHS

Contain (Covenant Objective)

Recover the cup before the auction closes. Deliver to a Keep vault. The monk performs the restoration ritual or confirms the quiescence condition. The cup is stored upside-down on a surface untouched by violence – the stone sewn into Shi Yánxìn's robe. The cup goes quiet.

Deny Use

Prevent any bidder from taking possession. If the auction happens, intercept the handoff. The cup must not leave Macau. The pharma company is reckless, not hostile – they can be outmaneuvered. The terrorist cell is inexperienced – their leader can be flipped, their second-in-command must be stopped.

Witness and Report

The auction completes. A bidder takes the cup. The Covenant must track and recover – a much harder operation. The Decay track advances. The cup is in the wind with an owner who intends to use it. This is the "case with a scar" outcome.

Catastrophe

The cup is used. A water supply is poisoned OR Daewon synthesizes and releases a "treatment" derived from the poison. The Decay track advances by 3. If the catastrophe is a poisoned water supply, thousands die within hours. If it's Daewon's "cure," the death toll is slower but global – a treatment regimen that secretly kills patients over weeks. Either outcome is a campaign-defining failure.

DA CHECKLIST – BEFORE SESSION 1

TASK	DONE
Print Operations Board + Organization Reference	☐
Print Location Pages L1-L7	☐
Print NPC Cards NPC1-NPC8	☐
Print and cut Information Cards I1-I22	☐
Print Relic Sheet	☐
Give players Case Brief – Player	☐
Start clock: Day 10, Morning	☐

KEY DRAMATIC BEATS

1. **Day 10-9:** Agents arrive in Macau. Rosário is cooperative but slippery. The cup is in a safety deposit box – agents can't access it without Rosário's key OR a bank heist.
2. **Day 8:** Relic Milestone – the cup's Corruption signature spikes. It's been moved for a private viewing. A plant in the viewing room is dead. The bidders have seen it.
3. **Day 7-6:** The monk makes contact. He's been watching the agents since they arrived. He reveals the cup's origin and the restoration ritual. The pharma team arrives in Macau.
4. **Day 5:** Relic Milestone – the cup's "personality" becomes more pronounced. It starts humming audibly. Rosário can't sleep in the same building. The terrorist cell's second-in-command (Nasim) becomes obsessed.

5. **Day 4-2:** Trail leads to the bidders. Agents must navigate Daewon's corporate security, the terrorist cell's safe house, and the monk's cryptic guidance. Chinese State Security activates.
6. **Day 1:** Catastrophe – the auction at an abandoned Portuguese fort on Coloane. All parties converge. The cup is on a table. Someone is about to win. The monk is in the back, waiting.

RUNNING THE AUCTION CLIMAX

The fort scene. Rosário is the auctioneer, terrified. The terrorist cell leader (Farouk) is visibly shaking – he doesn't want the cup, he's afraid of it, but his second (Nasim) is pushing him. The Daewon CEO (Park) is serene, convinced this is destiny. The Daewon R&D head (Yoon) is in a hazmat suit in the van outside, ready to receive the cup. The monk is present – he's not bidding, he's waiting to see what happens. The agents want containment. The auction is a sealed-bid format – bids were submitted 24 hours ago. Rosário is about to open the envelopes. The winner takes the cup. The agents must act before the envelope is opened or intercept the handoff after.

Manage the climax as a tense negotiation, not a firefight – though fire is one bad roll away. Nasim is a catastrophe vector. Park is unreachable by reason. Farouk wants someone to stop this. The monk is ready to act if no one else does. The agents have one chance to get this right.